

61.2
GMS
plastic produced per capita per day by Goa; Delhi is at 37 gms; National avg: 8 gms.

287
GMS
per capita per day is the US avg; UK: 271 gms

9,200
MILLION
tonnes of plastic produced globally between 1950-2017

plastic as a strict policy is one part of a bargain we must strike with the future. The other is to think local: the richer countries have been tipping their garbage vans on the poorer South, and everyone has been caught up in the 'Not In My Backyard Spirit' after China banned the import of plastic waste in 2018. But we must look after our own backyard—producing, recycling and incinerating safely within our cities, closing the loop as it were. India's plastic waste problem is still not as big as that of the West, but we're getting there. Rich states like Goa produce over 60 grams per capita per day; Delhi is catching up with 37 gm per capita. India's per capital average, around 8 gm, ranks low but our population means we are the No. 2 producer in the world. Globally, over half of all the plastic produced since 1950 was produced in the last dozen-odd years. As we aspire for a $5-trillion economy, we must keep an eye out for this graph—it maps our disaster. ■

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APNA DAL RIFT

FAMILY FEUD

By Prashant Srivastava

In Uttar Pradesh, the Kurmi community is considered the second-most influential OBC (other backward classes) group after the Yadavs. Both the ruling BJP and the principal opposition, the SP (Samajwadi Party), have Kurmi allies—the BJP has the Anupriya Patel-led Apna Dal (S), while the SP has the Apna Dal (K), led by her mother Krishna Patel, backed by her other daughter, Pallavi. The two factions are presently locked in a family feud to claim the legacy of Sonelal Patel, the founder of Apna Dal. Wife or daughter? Who should inherit the right to claim that they represent the community?

A major flashpoint between the two came over the birth anniversary of Sonelal on July 2 at the Indira Gandhi Pratisthan in Lucknow. Krishna and Pallavi had sharp words for Anupriya, alleging that she and her husband Ashish were behind the application filed by Krishna to host the commemoration being cancelled. Instead, it was the Anupriya-led Apna Dal (S) that did the honours. "Before being a father, Sonelal was a husband. I have the first right over him. Who is she to snatch [away] my rights?" Krishna reportedly asked.

Sonelal was a close aide of Kanshi Ram and a founding member of the BSP (Bahujan Samaj Party). He founded the Apna Dal in 1995. After his death, Anupriya contested the 2012 assembly election from Varanasi's Rohania, winning the seat, and then the 2014 Lok Sabha polls from Mirzapur, winning again. The same year, Krishna was defeated in the contest for her daughter's old seat, Rohania. Sources say this is when a rift first appeared between Krishna and Anupriya, leading to the latter forming her own breakaway party, the Apna Dal (S). In 2022, Krishna Patel's Apna Dal (K) allied with the SP for the assembly elections, with Pallavi Patel defeating deputy CM Keshav Maurya at the polls.

A source in the Apna Dal (K) says, "Earlier, Anupriya's faction had more power, because she is a central minister and her husband is a cabinet minister in UP. Now, after defeating UP's deputy CM at the polls, Pallavi has also gained a lot of traction." When it comes to the fight over Sonelal's legacy, Pallavi says, "Every year, supporters commemorate his birth and death anniversaries. This year, the plan was to hold [a celebration] in Lucknow. We sought permission to do so at Ravindralaya, then at Vishveshwarya auditorium and then at Mercury auditorium of the Indira Gandhi Pratisthan." After permission was denied, Krishna and Pallavi organised protests in Lucknow, which resulted in them being taken into custody.

Who inherits the legacy of Sonelal Patel? Wife or daughter? It's a critical question: it opens the door to a powerful OBC group.

The fight over Sonelal's legacy is not a trivial one. Both parties are keen to be seen as the real torchbearers, because that opens the doors to a prosperous OBC community that's a major electoral factor in over a dozen eastern UP districts, including Pratapgarh, Prayagraj, Sonbhadra and Mirzapur. Prof Pankaj Kumar of Allahabad University's Political Science department says the fight will grow fiercer as the 2024 Lok Sabha polls approach—and both factions seek a stronger leverage during alliance talks. ■



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

FACING OFF (Clockwise from top left) Anupriya, Krishna and Pallavi Patel